

10.4 Preparation

Students should do some background research for their individual investigation. This research should help them identify and define a biological question or problem that can be addressed and provide a clear rationale for their work. They should consult appropriate sources, which may include textbooks, magazines and journals, CD ROMs and the worldwide web. Reports should include a bibliography of the sources consulted and references to electronic materials should give the date of access and contain sufficient detail to allow the reader to check the source.

In advance of the data collection phase, students should devise and plan their experimental activities to make good use of the time and facilities available. They should consider appropriate methods, choose effective and safe procedures and select suitable techniques. They should decide what apparatus they will need, and check that this will be available for their use. They may devise their own apparatus or experimental set-ups, modify standard apparatus or use standard items in ways that are novel.

Students should have some idea of how they expect the work to proceed but should also be prepared to modify their plan in the light of initial results. It is, therefore, advisable that students should carry out a brief trial, in advance of the main data collection phase, to check the feasibility of their proposed work.